

Chapter I

A Hero's Welcome

There are not many sights quite like Hylestus during celebration. The city itself has always been beautiful with its hanging gardens, pristine white stone work, and staggering size. But when there is something for the many people of Hylestus to celebrate they strive to add as much colour and life to the streets as they can.

It feels strange to Oberon marching an army into a city, while the people cheer and applaud. Being at the head of the formation, atop a jet black stallion, Oberon is even thrown laurels of purple and white flowers by the adoring crowd. It makes him flinch.

Only three weeks ago he rode into a city just as ancient as this one. But they showered him with curses, not adoration. That was the prize of conquest. When he was younger he had always believed what the stories had told him. Those of heroes who won glory and honour by fighting, by conquering. But through his adventure he had only seen death, and its many friends.

As the army continues to move deeper into the city another rider moves in closer to Oberon. He looks over to see a true Harkon, and not one of those frivolous girls native to this land. A woman with blood from his homeland, clad in glamorous plate armour, its silver catching the sunlight, and the eagle head helm staring unnervingly at him. Iya Vienna, pride of the Capitol, grand-daughter of the King. That's what she looked like now. Not the shy young girl Oberon once knew.

"You're sulking." Iya says bluntly.

"I'm not sulking." Oberon replies, not failing to hear the bitterness in his own voice. "It's just... Doesn't this feel odd to you? All these people, cheering for us."

Iya's eagle helm scans the group around, and she waved at a group of young recruits holding a large Vienna flag above their heads. "Maybe a little," she admits, "but this is what we've been fighting for right? Fame and glory?"

"Honour and glory." Oberon mutters.

"Oh yes, *Honour*. A word you Protivera's never seem to forget."

Oberon shoots Iya an irritated glare.

“Look, Oberon, I’m sorry.” Iya sighs, “I didn’t mean to offend. I just don’t like seeing you like this. All... restrained and quiet. You never used to act so reserved. You used to take pride in what you accomplished, not melancholy.”

“We haven’t accomplished anything, Iya. The rebels still fight us, the bandits still rule the south, the Anzeni still hold their borders against us, and the Sorvs...”

“Who cares about the Anzeni? Or the Sorvs for that matter?” Iya cuts in, “They keep to themselves. As for the rebels, we crushed them in the Deep Lands. They are nothing more than a wounded band of delinquents, rotting away in the deep, frigid south now.”

“And we’ll just allow them to lick their wounds, and grow their strength?” Oberon persists.

“They will be dead by the end of the year. Face it Oberon, you have no choice but to enjoy yourself. Nothing that isn’t worth celebrating.”

Oberon doesn’t respond, but looks up at the now looming walls of the White Towers. Three nights of drinking, feasting, and speeches awaits him in those towers. He feels a little sick just thinking about it.

Iya leans in closer, looking at Oberon's grey plate armour. She scoffs.

“What is it?” Oberon asks, a little self conscious.

“Is that the same suit you wore on the campaign?”

“Uh, yeah.” Oberon responds, “I did clean it up a bit before we arrived.”

Iya rolls her eyes and scowls.

“It’s barely even scratched. I had to get a new set delivered ahead of us.” She mutters, “You do have something to celebrate Oberon, so enjoy yourself. That’s an order.”

With a smile, Oberon nods, and Iya moves back to her place in rank.

The grand hall was even more decorated than the city below. Every brazier and torch burned with varying colours. Tables stand lined with golden platters, cups, and utensils. And banners the size of small vessels hang from the rafters, each one the colour of a united House. One hundred and sixteen, well, seventeen now. In fact the large green

and yellow banner of the Lipsine is being raised beside the throne as Oberon enters with the High Lords and Ladies of his campaign.

Noble men and women line the tables middle and back tables keeping the head tables, the ones closest to royalty, free for the returning victors. They stand and applaud, making the room shake like thunder. The High Lords beam and wave proudly. Iya is the only one other than Oberon to remain composed. They walk side by side to the bottom of the stairs, stopping just short of the High Table.

There the throne rests in front of a massive stained glass window, portraying the twelve High Gods, standing side by side in solidarity. On the throne sits the aged Nero Vienna, King of Nuarivera. Despite his age he strikes an imposing figure. A man of Harkon, like Oberon. A man of war. He stands, the golden lines that weave a tapestry over the edges of his flowing purple cape clint in light. The King claps softly. Beside him, his daughter, a slender, sharp faced woman named Myra rises inferiorly and gestures for the room to be silent.

“High Lords and Ladies.” Myra speaks, her voice ordered and calm, “Welcome home.”

The room erupts in another bout of cheers and applause. Myra smiles diplomatically but Oberon could see the annoyance in the corners of her face.

“You fought bravely in the Deep Lands!” Nero’s voice booms throughout the hall, making all fall silent. He looks at Iya with warm eyes, “My lovely grand-daughter, what news do you bring us?”

All eyes fall on the eagle helm as Iya finally removes it and places it under her arm.

“The rebels...” Iya calls, “Have been defeated!”

More cheers. More applause. More glory given for the bloodshed. Oberon had thought maybe, just maybe, that when the time came to return that the reward would be worth the price. But it all makes him feel hollow.

“The last of them have fled to Jaka,” Iya continues, “Where they will freeze, starve, and die in the snowy wastes. Our brave men and women have secured liberty for the Clans of the Forest. Their Arch-Druids have accompanied me here, so that they may thank Your Grace, in person.”

Eyes turn now to the small Ver dressed in green robes, standing with humility behind Iya.

“And it is a pleasure to see them once again.” Nero beams, “Durule, how are you my old friend?”

“I am well, Your Grace.” replies the head of the Druidic Circle. A short, long bearded Ver, with a glistening emerald gaze. There is no white of his eyes, like all Ver, the look has always unsettled Oberon. “The rebels caused much damage to me and my people, they took up positions in our ancient homes and temples. They threatened our leaders with violence, and strong-armed our people into doing their bidding. But, your army was mighty, and the traitors were no match for their blades.”

Another round of obnoxious applause as the King salutes the Ver dutifully, who bows deeply in turn. Do these people not know? Oberon wonders. No, how could they. All they hear is what they are told. The rebels weren’t crushed by their army, they nearly destroyed it. Out of the fifteen hundred soldiers sent into the Deep Lands, only eight hundred returned. But that must be known. Such a loss cannot be ignored. Surely all those lives will not be forgotten.

“Lady Iya of House Vienna.” Nero calls over the chatter, “I charged you with carrying out your first mission, for the first time as the head of an army. And you succeeded.” The King glances at Myra, “You led with supremacy. Won a grand victory over our enemies. And proved yourself as a tactician, and a leader. For this I promote you to Commander of the Royal Infantry. May you lead with honour, and claim many more victories for your King, my kin.”

With much more ovation, Iya, now down on one knee, salutes with a closed fist to her chest, before rising and bowing to the King.

“Now I ask you for another favour. After the festivities and celebration, I want you to march south once again. It is my wish that the rebels, cold as they may be,” the crowd chatters with laughter, “Shall meet their end once and for all. *Strong Be The Blood.*”

“Thank you, Your Grace. Thank you, High Lady Myra.” Iya says, her head bowed in deep respect and humility. And by the sound of her words, Oberon knows

that she is hurt by this order. He had thought that, despite that horror of war, Iya would be elated by a promotion like this. It is everything that she had ever worked for. But he can see it in her eyes as she takes her place at the King's table. She is angry. Oberon stares at her as one by one the other High Lords and Ladies of his party receive their praises and rewards. The King's voice echoes as the hall blurs in Oberon's vision. With each acclaim he hears the roar of fire. With every boast of achievement he hears the mother torn from her child. With every cheer, he hears the silence of an empty battlefield.

He closes his eyes, and tries not to hear them all.

"Lord Protivera?" The King asks wryly.

Oberon's eyes snap open. Everyone is looking at him. Some seem amused, others annoyed. He had been addressed it seems, but had not come forward. Quickly, he moves in front of the High Table, and kneels before the King.

"My apologies, Your Grace." Oberon stammers as a light chuckle rises from the nobles, "I am weary from the journey."

"No need to apologise, my boy." Nero replies with a smile, "I have heard so many tales of your exploits."

Oberon raises his head, eyebrows raised in surprise.

"Oh yes, Lord Protivera, so many stories." he clasps his hands together, a wicked grin slashing across his face. "It is said that if you need a man killed, send a Harkon. If you need a hundred men killed, send a Protivera. You have proved the old adage true."

A deep, uneasy silence fills the room. Though he is from a prominent house, few know much about the third born child of Galeedeus. When Oberon was ordered to join the campaign, the courts whispered of his abilities. Many thought the untested boy was not ready for war. That he would fall in battle, or into obscurity. But his deeds proved them wrong.

Not knowing how to break the silence, Oberon replies flatly, "I suppose so."

"And modest, as well!" The King exclaims, "A young lad, with no experience in real combat, sent to fight rebels in unfamiliar terrain! And fight you did."

Then the King does something that surprises Oberon, and most others in the room. He steps down from the High Table, and sweeps across the stone tiles to stand

over the kneeling soldier. Oberon looks up at him, the mighty ruler of Nuarivera, and most powerful man in Ono Kām. The King places a hand on his shoulder, and speaks very softly.

“You fought, my boy. I know I sent you to a place you did not want to go. I know I separated you from your family, your home. I know I asked you to endure many terrible things. I am grateful that you fulfilled your oath.”

A band of pressure tightens around Oberon's chest. He is in the place he had always dreamed of. In the presence of the King, recognised as a man worthy of his respect. But he feels hollow. For he does not feel like a hero.

“Such loyalty to your King must be rewarded.” Nero continues.

“I ask nothing of you, Your Grace.” Oberon says quickly, thinking of how much he does not want the gift Iya received.

“No?” Nero inquires, “Others believe that such feats deserve appropriate rewards. Most men who find themselves in your place would ask for wealth, land, a title of renown.”

“I swore an oath.” Oberon responds simply, determined to end this situation as quickly as possible. “I swore to serve you. To obey your orders. And to protect you from those who would harm you.”

Nero removes his hand. The King observes Oberon with a scrutinizing gaze. His warm smile is gone, replaced by an impenetrable gaze. All Vienna's have eyes of deep purple. In Iya's, Oberon can see warmth, ambition, and assuredness. In Nero's, he only sees cold intelligence.

“Lord Protivera, you are a man of honour,” Nero begins in a low tone, leaving a heavy pause that makes Oberon want to look away. But he does not. “In this world, true honour is rare. Too often do the darker impulses of man overwhelm the subtle light that rests within. But in you I see a light that burns bright. It shows me a man who is resilient. A man who is brave. And most of all, a man that is loyal.”

The King raises his arm to his chest, and unbuckles the clasp of his cape. The flowing purple fabric falls into his hands, and brushes against Oberon's face. Up close he can see the intricate golden patterns. They are images of the Gods. Not the twelve who

are so often singled out for their power and majesty, but the hundreds of deities that once called this place their home.

“You have done your King, and your people, a great service.” His voice booms throughout the room once more, “And you ask of me nothing in return. You are the image of honour, duty, and loyalty. You have excelled. You have risen above your peers. Yet nothing is what you want.”

Oberon stares, praying for his words to end here.

“But, I cannot give you what you want!”

His heart drops.

“Such a service requires a suitable reward! So, Lord Oberon Protivera, I am making you a knight of my court.”

The room erupts in applause, and Oberon feels his spirit die.

As people stand, clap, and cheer, Nero drapes his cape over Oberon’s shoulders.

“Now arise, Oberon, of the House Protivera!” Nero cries over the cacophony, “Arise as Sir Oberon Protivera! Guardian of Nuarivera, Protector of the People, and Knight of the Royal Court!”

Oberon rises. Clasps Nero’s outstretched hand. Says a thank you that he cannot hear, bows, and steps up the High Table next to his father. Galeedeus’ face does not change as Oberon takes his seat. His expression is as unreadable as always. His father only nods curtly, before turning his attention back to his King.

Nero addresses the hall, and launches into a rousing speech. Oberon watches, but cannot listen. His fate is sealed. There was no way he could turn down such a gift. To do so would have severe consequences, and not just for himself. Yet he wishes he had. To have walked out of the hall, away from these binding chains. Would that not have been better?

He looks down the table to Iya, who is sitting next to her mother. The girl he has known since they were children glances over at him. She gives nothing more than a meager smile.

The night stretches for an eternity. The longer he sits, the more exhausted Oberon becomes. Many make their way down the High Table, giving their own praises to each who has earned their place. Oberon shakes their unscarred hands, listens to their worthless opinions, and endures their unrequested commendations.

As wine begins to flow in full, music rises from the mezzanine. Noble men and women take to the floor to dance with the rigid movements that are the Nuariveran tradition. They look like barely animated statues, Oberon thinks. In Harkon they dance like they fight. With boldness, fury, and skill. And these peoples clothes are so tight, and stained with clashing vibrant colours. Back home they dress as they are. Warriors attend events in the same clothes they train in. Farmers, the clothes the sow in. Riders often wear nothing at all.

This place is not his home. And he knows that will never be.

As midnight draws near Galeedeus finally moves. He stands and leans over the back of Oberon's chair.

"Meet me in the House of the High tomorrow morning." His father mutters gruffly in his ear. And without another word he straightens and leaves the hall.

Oberon stays for a moment more. But he cannot stand the revelry anymore. So he too gets up and leaves the hall.

Oberon pushes through the last of the crowds. They are all engaged in their vices, and few notice him passing by. So, soon the corridor is out before him, and he is ready to head straight to the barracks before anyone can trap him in conversation again. He makes it ten metres before a gauntleted hand grabs his arm. He turns to see Iya, red faced from wine and smiling broadly.

"Leaving so soon?" she asks with a childish giggle Oberon hasn't heard in ages. She shakes the bottle of wine, "The party has only just started."

"I'm tired, Iya. I'm going to bed." he grumbles.

"Tired? I have seen you march for sixteen hours straight. You only stopped when I ordered you to. I think you can handle an hour of being social." she remarks.

"Why are you in such a good mood?" Oberon says bluntly.

“Shouldn’t I be?” Iya asks, her smile falling a little.

Oberon can see that Iya is drunk. She sways on the spot, smiling in a way that requests he smiles back. He just shrugs.

“Well, I am in a good mood and your brooding is bumming me out.” Iya effuses as she grabs a handful of the cape around Oberon’s shoulders. She rubs the purple fabric through her fingers, gazing down at a golden moon embroidered on the hem. “So, Sir Oberon, I think you should have some wine, and join the party. A knight should always aid their Commander, and I require further indulgence in wine and dancing.” Iya places her bottle of wine in his hand. “Or, if the cityfolk are making you sick we could walk the gardens?”

“I don’t drink, Iya.” Oberon mutters, pushing the wine back into her hands.

Iya raises an eyebrow, a sly smile on her lips. “Really? Have you forgotten our time as recruits? I recall you being far more fun back then. What has changed, Oberon?”

Oberon knuckles turn white. Iya’s cheery attitude rubs him like a bed of nails. It is not that he wants her to be upset, but he knows what he saw in that hall, and he doesn’t like the facade Iya has adopted.

He looks around the hallway to assure there was nobody who could overhear them, and responded through clenched teeth. “What changed? Everything has changed, Iya. You know what it was like. You were there with me. The raids, the brutality, the war.

“I saw you up there, Iya. When High Lady Myra promoted you, you looked crushed. Like you hadn’t just had your dream come true. But, you saw what your future holds. The same shit that we have been rolling around in for months. You got everything you ever wanted, yet you looked like you wanted to be anywhere else when Nero made you Commander of his army.”

Iya rolls her eyes. “You weren’t looking properly then. I am very proud of what I have achieved, and honoured by the approaching Anointment.” she states, in a clipped tone, her smile long fallen from her face.

“Oh come on, Iya, I know what I saw,” Oberon growls, “And I know you. You don’t want this.”

Iya stares daggers at Oberon, all cheer gone. She stands there shaking, her fist clenched so hard around the bottle of wine Oberon worries it will shatter.

“You clearly don’t know me at all, Sir” Iya spits.

The two of them glare at each other for a long moment. Then, Iya turns on her heels and storms back into the hall. Oberon watches her leave, and continues to stare at the heavy wooden doors that she shut behind her. Feeling the heavy weight on his chest pushing down harder than before.